Stand And Deliver (Your Heart To Me)

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Stand And Deliver (Your Heart To Me)

by Lisra

Summary

They have been dating for a month. Catra needs a plan. Fortunately, she now has new friends.

Notes

This takes place a month after "blonde in shining armor", which was based on drawings by Iria Abella and got graced by more drawings from Henar Torinos, working as ilikeyoucatradora. Perhaps this will also inspire more drawings? Thank you to lyssandia for betaing this fic and to the She-Ra servers I'm active on for being so supportive!

See the end of the work for more notes

Present time, almost four weeks after getting together

Catra is a fuzzy bundle of nerves. It's their first anniversary. OK, monthly anniversary, but that still has to count for something, right? Four entire weeks without Adora realizing she could have someone who isn't like Catra is right now, a quivering mess of fur clutching a laptop in the corner of a darkened room, and four entire weeks without Catra turning tail and running for the hills. It must be love.

Scorpia had asked why Catra didn't just take Adora out to the quiet restaurant that makes your favorite. It had been a good question, but Catra had dismissed it out of claw. Taking Adora to the hybrid friendly meat palace would be too simple. Adora is her literal knight in shining armor, although she only wears the impressive armor for special occasions, a warrior princess, one of the best historical reenactment fighters in the country. Catra wants to do something special for her special person. So she whips her tail, growls at her screen and looks for anything that might spark an idea.

It's no use. She hates all the suggestions and all the date ideas. Are all the writers of dating advice websites straight, white, neurotypical and fully human? Probably. Another message from Scorpia pops up.

"Blossom says make it personal" she reads and groans. Scorpia's girlfriend means well and they both try to get along, but in Catra's opinion the florist girl has been spending too much time next to thornapples and belladonna. Make it personal, what else? Groaning, she pushes the laptop away and curls up on the rug, one hand fidgeting with her own tail. Her mind runs on two tracks now, one imagining Adora's disappointment when Catra can't think of anything, and one digging through her brief four weeks together. Suddenly, the spiraling thoughts of *you haven't even been over to her place and you haven't done more than* - are pushed aside by a different, more vivid memory.

Almost four weeks earlier, after the tournament

Adora is still wearing her armor. She is sitting on a crate, a towel around her neck and a look of exhausted satisfaction on her face. All around them knights are having their armor removed, weapons are maintained and horses cared for. Catra is standing in front of Adora, clutching a very modern slushie cup. She had been telling the blonde how relieved she was that she was unhurt.

Adora looks at her eyes clearly seeing something else. Catra wonders if she has heard anything she had said to her.

"Oh, as thou wish, mysterious lady, but I can think of other ways in which thou mightst relieve me!"

Catra blinks at her as her brain struggles to pick up the words in the midst of the hubbub. Then a blush of deep crimson hits her face and she nearly crushes her cup.

"What?" she splutters, tail whipping.

“Oh!” Adora yelps, blushing just as hard, “uhm, sorry, my mind was elsewhere. What were you saying..?”

Later, when Adora learns about Catra’s Olympic fencing ambitions, she gets the same far away look in her eyes, as she mimes the size of boots she imagines Catra could wear rapier, cloak and hat. She has to tell Adora that she isn’t that kind of fencer.

Present time

It’s a thrilling idea. It’s also scary as fuck and probably beyond her financial means. She has taken on data entry work from home in secret to earn some extra cash, but that probably won’t be enough, this stuff is expensive… This means she needs to ask for help. This means talking to people. Catra is purring now in the dark, trying to soothe herself. Just imagine Adora’s face when she sees you, that cute blush she gets when you surprise her and that big goofy smile that calms your heartbeat and makes your tail move and then she would come closer and put her arms around you to pull you close and you would stand on your tiptoes and kiss and… Catra groans again and thumps her tail on the ground. Calm yourself, she tells herself and shakes her head and ears as if that could dislodge the vivid thoughts from her mind.

She jumps on her bed and curls up with her phone. Let’s get this over with, she thinks, and dials.

It rings three times.

“Hi Catra, what’s up!”

Catra flicks her ears and turns the volume down. How is this girl always so loud?

“Hey, uh, Glimmer,” she stammers, her swagger non-existent, because this is about something important. She could tease the girl with her many colored hair all day about trivial things.

“I was wondering if you could… help me with something?”

There’s a pause on the other end of the line, as Glimmer considers the enormity of this moment. In the few weeks they had known each other, this has never happened.

“Look, “ Catra continues, before the second-thoughts can overwhelm her, “Adora’s your best friend, right? Well, our, uh, one-month anniversary is coming up and I want to do something special for her and... I need your help.”

She will laugh, Catra thinks. Everyone will, because four weeks is nothing. People get parties thrown for them if they stay married for decades, no one cares if you stay together for a month, but it matters to Catra because no one has been with her for four weeks until now… She flexes her claws with one hand and pats the bed for a fidget toy. She needs to occupy her hand asap.

“A month?” Glimmer asks after another pause, “my, how the time flies.” Her tone is impossible for Catra to place. She can’t tell if the girl is making fun of her or not.

“Sparkles, if - ,”

“Of course I’ll help you.”

Catra blinks, finally finds a cube she can twist in her hand and stutters again.

“Th-th- a- thank you, Glimmer.”

Glimmer huffs.

“If you don’t want to come over to talk about it, you have to text me your address, because I don’t actually know where you live.”

“You should try saying that in a more threatening voice, Sparkles!”

“Oh, just text me, fleabag.” Catra knows that voice. It means affection. Somehow she has another friend now and it’s frightening. In a good way.

A few hours later

“Someone is at the door” a mechanical voice says, startling Catra out of her nap. After the excitement of calling Glimmer she had felt so exhausted that she fell asleep where she was.

Catra’s roommate Alice has decked out their flat with a lot of smart gizmos that Catra didn’t bother to understand, but she understands the intelligent doorbell. She fumbles for the tablet that serves as the communication hub.

“Emily, show me the door.” She always feels a bit self-conscious talking to the computer, even when she is alone.

Glimmer's round face, topped by hair which showed vivid orange stripes, was looking impatiently in the direction of the camera.

Catra is suddenly glad she had fallen asleep. It left so much less time for her to panic. She presses the big green button on the screen.

“Be with you in a moment!” she calls and switches to a different settings menu. She turns on the lights in the apartment but leaves them a bit dimmed to go easy on her eyes. Then she tosses the tablet aside and steps over to her mirror. Dressed? Close enough. Hair? Controlled chaos. Fur? Clean.

Catra takes a deep breath and looks herself in the eye.

“You can do this. You know her. It will be fine.”

She doesn’t hate you for wasting her time, she wants to help you. She recalls the voice of her therapist, gentle but firm, reminding her. Catra smoothes out her tail and goes to the front

door. Posture. Smirk. Eyes up.

“Heeeey, Glimmer!” she purrs, the smirk becoming more of a grin.

Glimmer looks almost proper, like she hadn’t come over from home on a Sunday, but from the office.

“What’s with that getup? You’re not gonna advise me on my mortgage, are you?”

Glimmer huffs and steps into the apartment.

“I was visiting my mom earlier,” she explains as she takes off her shoes, “and up at Brightmoon Plaza they don’t even let you walk down the street in slacks.”

“What, really?” Catra has never been to that part of town.

“I mean probably not, but mom likes me looking smart.”

Catra sees the opening.

“Does she now? Maybe once we’re done, I can help you with that?”

Glimmer snorts and sizes her up. Catra is wearing shorts and a tank top she has had since she was fourteen years old.

“Dare I take fashion advice from the local scruff?”

“All the best fashion people dress like ass!” Catra claims as she leads Glimmer to the living room.

“Well your livelihood after your Olympic career is secure then,” Glimmer remarks. It had taken Catra some time to get used to the playful flinging of barbs as opposed to hurtful lashing out. She had always known how to do the one, even if she intended the other.

“If you’re done insulting me in my own home… can I offer you something to drink?”

Glimmer nods enthusiastically.

“Anything fizzy is fine.”

Catra doesn’t like the dry feeling of fizzy drinks, but Alice is at least mildly addicted to things that are fizzy and full of sugar, so they are always well stocked. Catra takes three cans out of the fridge and sets them in front of Glimmer, who is now sitting on the dark leather couch.

“I don’t know if any of those are good, I don’t deal well with sugar,” she informs Glimmer, who nods and grabs a can called Blue Alert with perfect confidence.

“This will do fine,” Glimmer declares and takes a long sip.

Catra fidgets with her fingers for a moment, then she sits down too.

“Alright, Catra, spill. You want to do something for a certain blonde girl. What’s your plan?”

Catra stares at the part of the couch that lies between them and thinks about her next words. She had made a list of things, but it’s back in her room and she doesn’t know if she can still go and get it. No, she can remember all of it!

“OK, so… first I need to know, how often does Adora practice and where? Have you been there?”

There’s some movement, probably Glimmer cocking her head.

“Why do you want to know?”

Catra squeezes her eyes shut. *Don’t snap, answer, explain* .

“I’ll explain. Can you just... Tell me first?”

Because then I’ll know if it’s even worth trying.

“Uh, okay? Well, there’s practice on Wednesday, Friday and competitions are on one of the weekend days. I’ve been to their practice places many times to watch her fight. Not like, with metal armor but with padded -“

“OK, great, I'll need you to do three things for me.”

Catra opens her eyes and looks straight at Glimmer, trying to force all of her earnest intent to show in her face.

Glimmer takes another sip of her Blue Alert.

“Okay, mysterious one, what’s the first?”

“Can you meet me at Forgotten Raiments tomorrow evening?”

“What?”

Catra has done her homework, casing where the majority of the Ren Fair regulars get their outfits made.

“You know the place! I need… well, I need your help and you surely know Esmeralda and got, like, a wink and a nudge when talking to her?”

Glimmer laughs.

“A wink and a nudge?”

Catra blushes and waves her hands in a distracted manner.

“You know what I mean?!” she protests.

“I really don’t, but I’m thrilled to know more,” Glimmer wiggles her eyebrows, which makes Catra look away and want to bite something, “so shoot, what are we doing in Esme’s domain of cloth and brocade?”

Catra raises a claw.

“Okay, so, listen. Right after the tournament…”

Glimmer listens. She laughs at the story. When she listens to the plan she vibrates and explodes with ideas at Catra.

Perhaps this expanding your social circle thing wasn’t so bad.

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Two days later, evening

The cool shift in the weather has made Catra glad she ditched her usual flannel shirt for a lined zip-up hoodie. Having a hood to put up makes the bus ride easier. Now she’s standing in front of the shop and hopes so much that Glimmer is already there.

Catra opens the heavy door to Forgotten Raiments with trepidation. She hates shopping, but shopping usually means malls, busy stores, loud music and several bus loads full of loud people. This is a single huge, dark and overly stuffed room with no one else visible. Her ears twitch in annoyance.

“Bagpipe music?” she mutters in disbelief and steps in. This might be some form of medieval torture for all she knows.

The store is filled with huge racks of clothing in strong colors and of odd shapes that mean little to Catra. She recognizes dresses, but almost everything else is just weirdly shaped cloth to her. It smells nice though. Natural fibers have a distinct smell that is not sharp like polyester is. There is, of course, a trace of incense in the air, mixed with polish, cleaning agents and strong alcohol. Other shelves are piled high with accessories, ranging from jewelry and belts to hats and bags. One wall is entirely covered with swords and other weapons, secured and only reachable via a ladder.

Catra stares at the wonders around her, while the bleating of the bagpipes assaults her senses. Her ears turn down as she takes a tentative step forward.

“Oh, I’m sorry, is it too loud, Miss?”

Catra hisses in surprise and almost jumps into a rack full of cloaks.

A woman has appeared next to her, wearing an emerald green dress and some sort of bonnet. Her delicate features and purple eyes mark her out as at least part fae.

“Oh, I’m so sorry for that too, what a dreadful way to enter my shop. Please!” She produces a very modern remote control stick and the bagpipes quiet down to a bearable level, if such a thing exists with bagpipes.

“Sorry again, Miss, that was very rude of me. That’s ten percent right off your first purchase and you can quote me on that!” Her voice is harmonious and seems to carry multiple tones of voice at once. Catra feels frozen, caught between her instinctual reaction and the fae’s disarming manner.

“Can I help you in any way? Looking for something particular or just browsing?”

Catra tries to get her fur to calm down. The questions loom up in front of her like armed targets.

“So, uhm, I was supposed to meet a friend here, short, colorful hair, uh, because I need - “ she stammers and fails. The swinging of the door saves her from answering. Glimmer sweeps in, that’s no exaggeration with her coat almost touching the floor, her eyes darting between Esmeralda’s bright, open expression and Catra’s awkward pose of hiding halfway under a van dyke brown cloak.

“Hi! Great that you’re already here Esme,” Glimmer rushes on without breaking stride, “my friend needs your complete expertise right now so if we could move?” She takes Catra gently by the arm and pulls her out of her freeze. Catra could almost kiss her for her timing. Esmeralda hops after them.

“Certainly, my queen,” she enthuses, “what can I do for you?”

They have reached a platform in the far back of the shop that isn’t visible from the front and Glimmer positions Catra in the middle like she’s an exhibit.

Somehow Esmeralda has already started to grab items from shelves even though she hasn’t even heard what Catra wants.

“Thanks Glimmer, “ Catra mumbles and squeezes her arm back. Glimmer gives her a smile and a nod.

“Okay, so what do you need?” the Fae asks again, “are you getting married? Bridesmaid? Got a LARP invitation and no idea what to wear?”

“So, what we need is -“

Catra holds up a hand.

“Have you seen The Three Musketeers?” she asks.

“Which one?” retorts Esmeralda, lifting her expressive eyebrows.

“Any really.”

“Dozens of times then.”

“Good. I want that spirit,” She grabs something that’s probably a measuring stick, “I want something that really sells this!”

She raises the stick like it's a sword. Puts her right foot on a stool and fixes them with her dual colored eyes.

"Sell that I'm the most dashing rogue coming to take. What. I want."

Catra can smell the change rolling off the Fae and sees the blush creeping up both Esme'sand Glimmer's face.

"I think," Esmeralda whispers, "I got just the thing for you."

Catra nods happily and drops her arm, tossing the stick up and catching it again.

"Don't spend it all on us," Glimmer hisses, "Rizz is a finite resource."

Catra snorts.

"Just give me a sword and I'll prove you wrong."

"You can't do that, I'm the queen!" Glimmer taps her index finger to her nose.

Catra has no idea where the energy is coming from, but she's flying on it now. She smiles showing all her teeth.

"Oh I'm sorry, majesty!" she bends her voice around the last word.

Glimmer, still red, stares right back at her.

"That's treason, missy!" she points out.

"Oh come on," Catra begins.

"To Adora?"

Catra's knees nearly buckle. The blow hits hard and unexpectedly, but she recovers enough to fight back.

"Oh don't flatter yourself. While you're distracted I'll steal your crown, your jewels and hang your lace undies on a flagpole for all to see and then I crown my own queen like she deserves."

She shrinks down some more, her bravado rapidly dwindling. Instead she turns away, looking where the shopkeeper has gone.

"Catra?"

"What?"

"They're not lace."

Catra whirls around but then decides she doesn't actually want to look at Glimmer right now.

“I did not need to know that!” she bristles, tail twisting around herself.

Glimmer steps closer without crowding in on her.

“Only teasing, Catra,” she says softly, taking out the barbs in her voice, “I know you’d never. Well, except steal my crown.”

Blushing and feeling completely out of her depth now, Catra flaps her hands a few times. She knows Glimmer was only winding her up and responding to her silly antics, but the suggestion still caught her off guard. Her mind conjures up images that are torn from nightmares and cheap romance novels. She would never. It would tear at her very being.

“I don’t think Adora would like a crown,” she whispers and looks at her shoes, “so you’re safe there.”

“Oh, good.”

They stand in awkward silence for a few seconds. Then, to their rescue, Esmeralda bustles back into view, carrying an enormous amount of clothing. She drops it on the platform with a huff and then drags a folding screen from between two racks.

“Please take off that ghastly hoodie, Miss, and we can start.”

It could scarcely get more embarrassing than it already is, Catra decides and grabs the hem of her zip-up.

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“How much?!”

“I know. But handmade leather booths that fit with your claws are expensive.”

Catra looks at the huge leather contraptions that are allegedly able to hold her clawed feet. She’s standing on the platform in a linen undershirt. It took them several tries to find a weave that she felt comfortable with on her skin.

“No,” she decides, “No boots. I’ll do without.”

Esme looks doubtful, because who has heard about a swashbuckling cat without boots and Catra feels only more strongly that she should not wear them. She’s going to be her own person, not some tribute to a stupid legend.

“Besides, I have the wrong fur color, the original puss was ginger.”

Someone grumbles that she’s just as spicy, but she ignores it.

“Okay,” Esmeralda concedes, “if boots are out we need to decide on colors. We can do an ensemble of green, robin hood style. Or perhaps vermilion.”

“Not green,” Catra says immediately and forcefully, causing the others to look up. She flinches back.

“No reason, I just, uh, don’t like the color. Works badly with my fur.”

“I think it could -“ Glimmer begins.

“No. Green.” Catra cuts her off and the shorter woman backs down.

“Well then,” the fae says brightly, “let’s give red a try.”

She fetches several items: hose, shirt, tunic and cloak. They seem impossibly heavy for mere clothing, Esmeralda is actually struggling to carry it all. Then she collects two big belts.

“Okay, so put these on,” she hands Catra the hose, “and then lift your arms,” she instructs.

It takes some time to get Catra into the costume. The tunic can be laced, showing a lot more figure than you would expect from a geometrically cut garment.

“Since this is not for authenticity, but for effect… how are you for more leather?”

“What do you mean?” Catra asks and tries to see what Esmeralda is fetching.

“This!” She holds up something that looks like a cross between a leather breastplate and a harness.

“Trust me,” the fae says and advances. Catra holds out her arms again and closes her eyes. It’s been a weird hour, surrendering control like that to someone whose purple eyes are as enchanting as they are denoting danger.

She feels the straps around her and a moment later there’s slight pressure on her chest, then her entire torso. Esmeralda doesn’t lace it up to its maximum, just enough to gently push up on her breasts.

“Okay, put down your arms,” Catra obeys again. The pressure of a cloak lands on her shoulder, and a clasp is fastened. The load feels grounding. Catra is really calm now, the solid pressure of the leather holding but not constricting her breathing.

“It.. Feels good,” she mumbles, feeling relieved.

“You look dashing,” Glimmer confirms.

“Okay… now you need a weapon.”

Esmeralda walks towards the counter in the far corner and picks up a bell. Catra and Glimmer share a confused glance as the fae rings. There’s an answering growl from deep in the backrooms of the store. Catra’s ears perk up.

“Is that..?” She asks and then she knows. From behind a dark curtain emerges the broad form of Herwyn, the bear hybrid she met at the weapons exhibition at the fair. He stops, his bold

beard that he styled out of his fur quivering with surprise.

“Why hello, fencer cat! I’m surprised to see you this quickly! Couldn’t resist the pull of the old dress-up game, could you?” his voice booms through the shop like a jovial earthquake.

“Dear, can you go and fetch this highwaywoman her sword?”

Herwyn sizes her up again, like he did all those weeks ago.

“Sure thing,” he decides and fetches the ladder. He climbs up the wall with surprising grace, like some bears are wont to do. What he fetches makes Catra’s eyes go wide. It’s a rapier, the blade long and thin with a heavily swept hilt and large pommel at the end. When he gently hands it to her, she’s again surprised at how heavy it feels. But it slips into her grip like it was meant to be there. Everyone backs away as she moves it around.

“That’s... amazing,” she admits.

“Told you,” Herwyn looks smug and proud, “I always know the right weapon for the right person.” He hands Catra a scabbard and she puts it into her belt, before sheathing the sword.

“And very good you do that, dear,” Esmeralda agrees, nudging his bulk, “but I think there’s yet another piece missing.”

What she fetches this time is tiny and made from almost the same vermilion color as her cloak. It’s a mask. Small, like the one worn by Zorro, the mythical hero of the fox hybrids. Esmeralda hands it to Catra almost reverentially.

“Try it on,” she urges.

Catra does so, hands shaking slightly. The fabric feels amazing on her face. Perhaps it’s velvet. She feels her entire posture changing as she ties it around her head.

When she turns to face her audience of three, she stands tall and confident. The rapier is out in the blink of an eye and she holds it out.

“Your money or your life,” Catra demands and bares her fangs in a smile.

Esmeralda quakes like she’s about to faint. The atmosphere changes. Catra nostrils flare.

“Perfect,” she states.

That’s step one down.

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The next Saturday

Catra is dressed up and ready. Only her mask remains. It’s on her knees along with her rapier as she waits behind a wall. Glimmer has sent her a text a few minutes earlier, saying that she has deposited Adora half a block away. She had been under clear instruction to make her

friend late for practice, something that Adora would otherwise never allow to happen. It gave Catra time to rally the other members of the historical martial arts club. Like all men who indulge in historical recreation, they have a love for the dramatic and agree to her plan, provided they are allowed to hide in the bushes. The bushes are the stands of the local basketball court, where the club trains on Saturdays and the men of the club, including Adora's twin brother Adam, are pretending to do their warm-up.

Catra doesn't come out from her hiding place when she hears the door opening and the stamp of running feet.

"Sorry guys! I'll be there asap!" Adora yells to the assembled multitude. Apparently, Adora usually leads practice and is there before anyone else. Another door, to the women's locker room, slams.

"Move it, boys!" That's Adam speaking. Catra hears the men move and in under two minutes all of them are lying down in the stands, hidden from view. Catra creeps to a new hiding place down at the court, behind the door to the changing rooms and tries to banish thoughts of Adora rapidly changing into her training gear. It's difficult. She has not seen everything she wants off her girlfriend yet, but the mind is powerful and sometimes what Adora wears, especially after training, leaves little to the imagination.

The minutes pass slowly and Catra's heart starts to hammer in her chest. Her hands are sweaty. She ties on her mask. Instantly, she calms down, straightens up.

Adora runs right past her onto the court. She is wearing her gambeson, thick pants and gloves. A meshed fencing mask is wedged under her arm. She stops, realizing something is off. There are the mats, the wagon full of practice swords and shields, but not a single person.

"Guys? Sorry I was late," Adora calls, unsure, looking around. Catra sees her fists clenching.

Catra slips out from her hiding place, her padded feet making no noise.

"Guys? If this is a prank, it's not very funny!"

Catra steps onto the court. Her blade glides from its sheath.

"Lady of Light!" Catra calls and Adora spins around. Her eyes widen as she sees Catra.

There is nothing unsure about Catra anymore. She walks with perfect grace and confidence, her tail barely visible between her cloak and corset. She raises her rapier, pointing it straight between Adora's eyes, as she stops two sword lengths away from her. Her girlfriend's eyes go wide, surprise and excitement coming off her in waves.

"Stand and deliver!" Catra demands, her voice strong and self-assured, "You have something that belongs to me!"

A smug smirk fights for space in Adora's face. She lets the fencing mask drop to the floor and takes a step back, raising her gloved hands slightly.

"Is that so, dashing mystery swordswoman? And what would that be?"

Catra circles her, eyes and blade never leaving their target. The cloak flows behind her.

“Something that belongs to a woman of your acquaintance.”

Adora raises her eyebrows.

“I’ve never taken anything from a lady that wasn’t given willingly!” she claims, taking a step towards the cart full of swords.

“Not so fast, lady. You stop right there. Hand over what I seek.”

Adora scoffs theatrically.

“And what is that… villain?”

Catra raises her free hand as a fist and shakes it.

“You call me a villain when you have taken… no, stolen… my heart!”

Adora’s eyes go wide again and her smirk wavers a little, as if she is trying to figure out where this is going.

“And I want it back, Adora, so…” Catra lets her arm down and drops the rapier, “so I can give it to you myself.”

Adora drags off her gloves as Catra saunters closer. When they are at arm's length, Adora extends an arm and puts one hand on Catra’s chest, just above where the corset ends. She flexes her fingers ever so slightly before withdrawing her arm. The contact sends a fire through Catra, but her costume keeps her strong.

“Here,” she says softly, “that’s yours.”

She’s smiling, her eyes soft. Catra mourns the loss of contact, but knows it won't be for long.

“And I know just what else to give you.”

Catra removes her mask and holds Adora’s gaze, small sparks of joy pulsing through her.

“And what is that?”

Adora steps forward slowly, holding out her arms. Catra enters her space willingly and shivers when she feels Adora’s arms encircling her. They hold eye contact for a few more seconds, then Catra closes her eyes and tilts her head up.

The kiss is everything she had hoped for, languid and caring, with Adora’s arms holding her as if she’s something precious and not the thing her dark thoughts tell her she is. No one had ever done so, no one had ever cared so much than this blonde idiot. Catra shivers again and opens her mouth, meeting Adora’s tongue. They part reluctantly.

“Mine,” Adora whispers, “I give mine to you, Catra.”

Tears well up in Catra's eyes and she let's herself be held against Adora's chest, wishing they weren't both wearing so much bulky stuff.

"I love you," Adora murmurs, nuzzling into Catra's mane. Catra tightens her own grip on Adora, words momentarily beyond her. Her head is swimming. This was perfect. Everything had worked. As she breathes in, she recognizes that smell. It's arousal. She smiles. Adora had given her heart to her. Said she loved her. Kissed her. Finds her desirable.

She has found something precious too and will not give it up. She wants to say it back.

"A-A-Ad-Adora, I-I, " she stutters out, cursing herself inwardly, as she reflexively sucks her breath back in, making it hard to speak. She wants to say it, but can't. Her body won't let her.

"Shhh, I know," Adora whispers, "I know. I know."

Catra just squeezes her back, overwhelmed with joy.

There are noises from far away. Then suddenly, a chorus of voices erupts.

"She-Ra! She-Ra! Cat-Ra! Cat-Ra!" the crowd chants. Catra imagines swords being held aloft.

"I'll kill all your friends," Catra forces out.

"I'll help," Adora agrees, but her tone is mild. In truth, not even cheering men, Adam loudest of them all, could mar this perfect moment.

From the entrance door, Glimmer gives them two thumbs up.

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Catra spends the time of the actual practice lying down in the farthest corner of the stands with her headphones in. Not only is the noise of everyone going through their fighting routines harsh and jarring, but she is also exhausted. But it's nothing that an hour in darkness with Bikini Kill in her ears wouldn't fix.

She feels Adora coming closer because she has one ear against the floor. She knows she made a mrrp sound when sitting up, because Adora's eyes are big and full of adoration. She suppresses the urge to pout and stretches instead.

"Hey, love," Adora greets her and sits down next to her. Catra immediately snuggles up to her and Adora enfolds her in an embrace just as quickly.

" *Love* , are we that far now?" she teases, kissing Adora's neck, before nuzzling against it.

"Oh we so are." She pauses for a breath, before going on, "that was awesome, Catra. You looked so good and… oh wow, I'm just… floored."

"I remembered what you said to me just after your fight against Adam."

Catra waits for the memory to return to her girlfriend.

“Oh no, you remembered, “ she groans.

“I do. It was funny, in retrospect. You are the worst at flirting.”

“I thought I did rather well earlier?”

Catra laughs.

“You did perfectly, dummy.”

Adora holds her tighter for a moment.

“Are you free tonight?” Catra asks, shy again.

“After that? I would be even if I wasn’t, Catra.”

Catra feels the warmth spread further through her. She could spend all evening snuggled into Adora on the ground, but she’d rather spend it somewhere softer.

“Good,” she breathes and turns to kiss Adora again, “because I have more to show you.”

Their kiss is another promise. Catra is a fuzzy ball of anticipation.

End Notes

Thank you everyone for reading, please consider commenting, it helps me stay motivated! Thank you to Henar and Iria for always promoting my fic along with their drawings and for inspiring me in the first place, you guys are awesome! Check their work as ilikeyoucatradora on insta and tumblr!

I don't know how i arrived at giving Entrapta the common name Alice in my modern AUs, but that's how it goes now. She's Entrapta when she's in the zone, or online, or whatever.

Please drop by the Archive and comment to let the creator know if you enjoyed their work!